

Discussion paper

LEADERSHIP IN THE AGE OF AI

Strategy, Innovation, and Decision-Making in a Transforming Economy



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Authors

Aashish Chaudhry, India
Amarjit Singh, UK
Anand Rao, UK
Bidisha Banerjee, India
Caroline Reiners, Germany
Chandrashekhhar Meled, India
Fatin Al Zadjali, Oman
Johannes Mario Schmidt, India
Johannes Samwer, Germany
Mahabeer Prasad, India
Parag Bawdekar, India
Rajesh Pandey, India
Rama Shankar Pandey, India
Sam Tully, UK
Sanj Naha, UK
Santosh Huralikoppi, India
Shipra Jha, India
Sneha Bhat, India
Snigdha Sudhir Manchanda, India
Vikramjeet Singh, India
Vinit Pardeshi, India

Editor

Teck Ming Tan, Finland

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Cambridge Judge Business School

Foreword



Jaideep Prabhu
Programme Director

The rise of AI marks a profound shift in how organisations create value and how leaders must think. Leadership today is no longer defined by scale or resources, but by the ability to innovate thoughtfully within constraints.

This white paper brings together insights from the Global India Leadership Programme at Cambridge Judge Business School, where leaders explored the opportunities and tensions of the AI era. A key theme was the importance of doing “better with less”, applying intelligence and discipline to build solutions that are efficient and sustainable.

As AI raises deeper questions of judgment and responsibility, I hope this report contributes to a broader conversation on how leaders can balance innovation with purpose in a rapidly changing world.



Mark Bloomfield
Programme Co Director

Artificial intelligence is not just a technological shift, it is transforming how decisions are made.

Throughout the programme, it became clear that AI is reshaping, not replacing, leadership. As intelligent systems take on analytical tasks, leaders must focus more on defining problems, exercising judgment, and ensuring responsible decision-making.

This white paper reflects that transition. The challenge is not simply adopting AI but integrating it into organisations in ways that balance capability with governance and human oversight.

As AI scales across industries, leadership will increasingly depend on the ability to work alongside intelligent systems. This report offers a perspective on what that evolution looks like in practice.



Suyash Bhatt
Founder & CEO, GEL

At Global Education Lab, we believe leadership is shaped by the quality of conversations at moments of change.

The Global India Leadership Programme brought together Cambridge faculty and global business leaders to explore how leadership must evolve in an AI-driven world. What emerged was not a single answer, but a set of critical insights, leadership today requires clarity, adaptability, and the ability to navigate complexity.

This white paper captures those insights as part of a broader, collaborative effort to advance thoughtful and responsible leadership.

We see this as the beginning of an ongoing dialogue. As AI continues to reshape industries, leadership must evolve alongside it.

Global Education Lab

Global Education Lab (GEL) is an innovation-driven knowledge transformation company, dedicated to shaping the next generation of global thinkers, leaders, and change-makers. GEL fosters a new model of education, one rooted in real-world application, accelerated learning, and global relevance. We stand at the intersection of academic excellence, entrepreneurial energy, and social impact, committed to building transformative experiences for learners and educators worldwide.

Artificial intelligence is not just transforming technology, it is redefining leadership itself. Drawing on insights from global executives and Cambridge faculty, this white paper explores how leaders must evolve in a world shaped by intelligent systems, rising complexity, and shifting global dynamics. It highlights a critical shift from execution to judgment, from scale to efficiency, and from control to augmentation. As AI reshapes decision-making, innovation, and governance, leaders must balance technological capability with human insight, ethical responsibility, and strategic clarity. The result is a new leadership playbook, one that is adaptive, globally aware, and built to navigate uncertainty in an increasingly AI-driven economy.

This report reflects independent perspectives emerging from the programme and is shared to contribute openly to global leadership discourse; the views presented are those of the authors, and any errors remain our own.

Programme Director

Jaideep Prabhu

Programme Co Director

Mark Bloomfield

Founder & CEO

Suyash Bhatt

Summary of the report

Context and Purpose

Leadership in the Age of Artificial Intelligence: Strategy, Innovation, and Decision-Making in a Transforming Economy brings together the key ideas, discussions, and practical insights from the Global India Leadership Programme 2026, held at Cambridge Judge Business School, University of Cambridge. Convened by Global Education Lab, the programme brought together senior leaders, entrepreneurs, and Cambridge-affiliated faculty to explore how leadership must evolve in a world increasingly shaped by artificial intelligence, global uncertainty, and systemic change.

This white paper reflects a collective effort to understand how organisations can navigate a rapidly changing environment where technological capability, geopolitical shifts, and stakeholder expectations are all intensifying simultaneously.

The Changing Nature of Leadership

A central argument of this report is that artificial intelligence represents more than technological advancement. It signals a fundamental shift in how organisations operate, compete, and make decisions. As intelligent systems become embedded across industries, leadership is being redefined.

The report highlights a clear transition from control to judgement. Leaders are no longer required only to process information and execute decisions, but to frame problems, interpret uncertainty, and guide organisations through complex and evolving environments. While AI can enhance analytical capability, it cannot replace the human responsibilities of leadership such as setting direction, exercising judgement, and maintaining accountability.

From Technology to Value Creation

Across the programme, it became evident that the true value of AI lies not in the technology itself, but in how it is applied. One of the most prominent themes is the importance of frugal innovation and frugal AI, where organisations focus on efficient, accessible, and targeted use of technology rather than pursuing scale for its own sake.

Leaders are encouraged to prioritise practical use cases, align AI investments with customer needs, and ensure that technological adoption translates into measurable business value. This approach is particularly relevant in environments where resources are constrained and impact must be delivered with precision.

Customer-Centric and Integrated Innovation

The report reinforces that successful innovation in the AI era must begin with a deep understanding of customer needs. Organisations that focus on real problems and user behaviour are more likely to create sustainable and differentiated value.

AI enables new forms of innovation across products, services, and systems. However, its impact depends on how well it is integrated into broader organisational strategy. Leaders must therefore align technology with culture, governance, and operational capabilities, ensuring that innovation is not fragmented but embedded across the organisation.

Governance, Responsibility and Trust

As AI systems increasingly influence organisational decisions, governance becomes a critical leadership priority. The report highlights the importance of building structures that ensure transparency, accountability, and ethical oversight.

Boards and leadership teams must develop a deeper understanding of AI systems to provide meaningful supervision. At the same time, organisations must strengthen incentive structures, risk management practices, and regulatory awareness to ensure that technological adoption supports long-term value creation rather than short-term gains.

Trust also emerges as a key theme. In an environment where AI can generate content and automate communication at scale, maintaining authenticity, credibility, and clear organisational identity becomes essential.

Leadership in a Complex Global Environment

The programme situates AI within a broader context of global transformation. Leaders today must navigate interconnected challenges including geopolitical uncertainty, sustainability pressures, demographic shifts, and financial volatility.

The report emphasises that these forces cannot be addressed in isolation. Effective leadership requires a systems perspective that integrates technology with resilience, sustainability, and long-term strategic thinking. Organisations must balance ambition with responsibility, and innovation with stability, to remain competitive in an increasingly fragmented and dynamic global economy.

From Insight to Action

Insights from programme delegates across sectors including banking, healthcare, education, manufacturing, consulting, and consumer industries demonstrate how these ideas can be applied in practice. A common theme is the need to bridge disciplines, combining technology with governance, strategy with ethics, and innovation with human-centred thinking.

These perspectives highlight that leadership is becoming more interdisciplinary and context-driven, requiring leaders to adapt their approaches across different markets, industries, and organisational structures.

Looking Ahead

This white paper presents a forward-looking perspective on leadership in the age of artificial intelligence. It suggests that the most effective leaders will be those who can combine strategic clarity with adaptability, technological confidence with ethical responsibility, and global ambition with human insight.

As the pace of change continues to accelerate, leadership will increasingly depend on the ability to navigate uncertainty, make informed decisions, and build organisations that are resilient, innovative, and purpose-driven. Artificial intelligence may transform the tools of leadership, but it also reinforces the importance of its fundamental principles: clarity, trust, judgement, and long-term vision.

Abstract

This white paper presents key insights from the Global India Leadership Programme 2026, held at the Cambridge Judge Business School. The programme explored critical themes including artificial intelligence, customer-centric innovation, frugal AI, global leadership communication, negotiation, corporate governance, and sustainability. Through lectures, discussions, and collaborative exercises, participants examined how technological transformation, shifting stakeholder expectations, and evolving global economic conditions are redefining leadership practices. The report synthesises the executive learning summaries from each programme session, highlighting key frameworks, practical insights, and their cross-industry implications. In addition, it presents perspectives gathered from programme delegates on future priorities for global leaders over the next five years, drawing on a pre-programme survey covering six interdisciplinary domains: Digital Transformation & Technology; Strategic Growth & Internationalisation; Sustainability & Ethics; Leadership, Culture & Human Capital; Corporate Governance & Institutional Frameworks; and Financial Stability & Economic Policy. Together, these insights offer a forward-looking AI perspective on how leaders can navigate uncertainty, technological disruption, and the growing complexity of global markets in the coming decade.

Introduction

The Global India Leadership Programme 2026, initiated by the Global Education Lab, brought together senior leaders, entrepreneurs, and academic experts to explore the evolving challenges and opportunities shaping global leadership in an increasingly complex and interconnected world. Held from 9 to 13 March 2026 at the Judge Business School, University of Cambridge, the programme was designed as an interdisciplinary executive learning experience that integrates perspectives from strategy, innovation, artificial intelligence, governance, negotiation, and cross-cultural leadership.

The programme took place across several historic venues in Cambridge, including the Fadi Boustany Room at Cambridge Judge Business School, the Newton Room at The Pitt Building, King's College, and St. Catharine's College. These settings provided an intellectually stimulating environment for dialogue, reflection, and collaboration among participants from diverse professional and geographic backgrounds.

A distinctive feature of the programme was that all sessions were delivered by instructors affiliated with the University of Cambridge, bringing world-class academic expertise together with practical insights relevant to leadership in global and emerging markets. Through lectures, case discussions, and interactive sessions, participants examined critical themes such as AI-driven transformation, corporate governance, innovation systems, customer-centric strategy, negotiation frameworks, and the evolving responsibilities of global leaders.

This white paper, titled “Leadership in the Age of Artificial Intelligence Strategy, Innovation, and Decision-Making in a Transforming Economy,” captures key insights from the programme. It synthesises the main concepts discussed during the sessions and reflects on their implications for leadership in an era defined by rapid technological change, shifting geopolitical dynamics, and expanding stakeholder expectations.

In the following sections, **Executive Learning Summaries from the programme's 12 sessions** are presented, highlighting the key insights and discussions from each topic. These are followed by a section titled **“From Insight to Action: Delegate Applications Across Industries,”** which showcases how delegates apply key insights in practice. This white paper concludes with a section titled **“Future Priorities for Global Leaders: Perspectives from Emerging and Global Markets with the Rise of AI,”** which compiles insights and reflections contributed by the programme delegates.

Part A: Programme Overview : Executive Learning Summary

The Global India Leadership Programme 2026 was designed as a rigorous, interdisciplinary executive experience addressing one central question: what does it mean to lead in an era defined by artificial intelligence, systemic uncertainty, and shifting global power structures?

To answer this, the programme was structured around **three interrelated intellectual arcs**. These arcs move deliberately from the individual to the organisational, and from operational capability to strategic and board-level judgement, reflecting the layered nature of modern leadership.

1. Leadership Foundations

The programme began by interrogating the foundations of leadership itself in an AI-mediated world. At its core was the recognition that while technology is advancing rapidly, the essence of leadership is becoming more—not less—human.

Sessions on *Communication and the Art of Leadership* reframed communication not as a soft skill, but as a strategic capability. Leaders were challenged to think of communication as the mechanism through which vision becomes action, and alignment becomes execution. The emphasis on rhetoric, narrative, and audience engagement highlighted that in a world of information abundance, clarity, authenticity, and emotional resonance become sources of competitive advantage.

This was complemented by *The Thinking Edge: How Leaders Win with AI*, which moved beyond technological awareness to cognitive augmentation. AI was positioned not as a replacement for human decision-making, but as a “thinking partner” that enhances judgement when used with structure and intent. Frameworks such as prompt engineering illustrated how leaders must learn to ask better questions, not just seek better answers.

The sessions on *Managing in the AI Era* and *Frugal AI Research* extended this further by addressing a critical gap in current discourse: the transition from experimentation to value creation. Participants explored why many AI initiatives fail to scale, uncovering challenges related to cost structures, governance, integration, and user adoption. The concept of frugal AI introduced an important counter-narrative to resource-intensive models, emphasising efficiency, accessibility, and real-world applicability over technological excess.

Across this arc, a deeper insight emerged: leadership in the AI era is less about mastering tools and more about orchestrating systems of people, technology, and judgement under conditions of uncertainty.

2. Governance and Innovation

The second arc shifted focus from individual capability to organisational design, exploring how leaders build systems that enable innovation while maintaining control, accountability, and legitimacy.

Sessions on *Corporate Governance* highlighted that governance is not merely a compliance mechanism, but a strategic architecture that shapes behaviour, incentives, and long-term value creation. Participants examined how boards allocate decision rights, design executive incentives, and manage conflicts of interest, particularly in environments where stakeholder expectations are expanding beyond shareholders to include society, regulators, and future generations.

This governance lens was deliberately juxtaposed with sessions on *Frugal Innovation*, *Customer-Centric Innovation* and the *Brand-Led Innovation Clinic*. Here, innovation was reframed as a systemic capability, not a function or isolated activity. Leaders explored how organisations that succeed in innovation integrate deep customer insight with internal capabilities, culture, and strategic intent.

A particularly powerful insight was the role of *Branding Strategies* as an organising principle. Rather than being confined to marketing, brand was positioned as a unifying logic that aligns products, processes, people, and communication, ensuring coherence across the organisation. This becomes especially critical in the AI era, where scale and automation risk diluting authenticity and trust.

This arc was further deepened through the session on *Leadership for a Sustainable World*, which positioned sustainability not as a peripheral agenda, but as a systemic leadership challenge. Participants examined how interconnected risks, from climate and geopolitics to technological disruption, require leaders to integrate sustainability, resilience, and ethical governance into core strategic and innovation decisions.

Crucially, this arc also emphasised the role of institutional and regulatory environments in shaping competitive advantage. Leaders reflected on how governance frameworks, policy regimes, and societal expectations increasingly determine not only what organisations can do, but how they are perceived and valued. In this sense, competitive advantage is no longer purely market-driven, but institutionally mediated.

The central insight from this arc is that innovation without governance leads to fragility, while governance without innovation leads to stagnation. Effective leadership requires the ability to design both simultaneously.

3. Strategy and Boardroom Impact

The final arc elevated the discussion to the strategic and boardroom level, where decisions carry long-term and often irreversible consequences.

Sessions on *Foundational and Scaling Business Strategies* revisited core strategic principles in the context of technological disruption and global uncertainty. Strategy was framed not as planning, but as a disciplined set of choices about where to play and how to win, requiring clarity, trade-offs, and alignment across the organisation. Participants explored how traditional frameworks such as competitive advantage, industry positioning, and resource-based views must evolve in a world where AI is beginning to reshape industry boundaries and redefine sources of value.

This perspective was deepened through *Boardroom Dynamics*, where the focus shifted to how decisions are actually made at the highest level. Participants examined the realities of board behaviour, including the tension between formal governance structures and informal power dynamics. Discussions highlighted that effective boards are not defined solely by structure, but by the quality of challenge, independence of thought, and willingness to engage in difficult conversations.

The programme included a *fireside conversation* and a thought provoking reflection during a *formal dinner*, offering a reflective counterpoint to the analytical sessions. Through the entrepreneurial journey of Lord Karan Bilimoria, leadership was grounded in values, resilience, and long-term conviction. The discussion reinforced that while strategies, technologies, and markets evolve, enduring leadership is anchored in integrity, purpose, and the ability to navigate adversity.

Part B: From Insight to Action: Voices of Global Leaders

Aashish Chaudhry, Amarjit Singh, Anand Rao, Bidisha Banerjee, Caroline Reiners, Chandrashekhar Meled, Fatin Al Zadjali, Johannes Mario Schmidt, Johannes Samwer, Mahabeer Prasad, Parag Bawdekar, Rajesh Pandey, Rama Shankar Pandey, Sam Tully, Sanj Naha, Santosh Huralikoppi, Sneha Bhat, Snigdha Sudhir Manchanda, Vikramjeet Singh, Vinit Pardeshi

B2B Manufacturing

During the group discussion, delegate Johannes Samwer from Rhenus Lub inspired a novel model entitled “**Frugal Framework for AI Implementation in Companies Operating under Conditions of Uncertainty.**” This framework is important because many organisations approach AI implementation in an unstructured and fragmented way, often leading to inefficiencies, misallocated resources, and limited impact. It provides leaders with a clear and disciplined approach to prioritizing AI initiatives by balancing operational efficiency with strategic innovation, while ensuring alignment with organizational capacity.

The key idea is that AI should be applied as a customer-centric tool, with deliberate selection of use cases, controlled scaling, and thoughtful allocation of resources, rather than pursuing widespread experimentation without focus. This enables organisations to navigate uncertainty more effectively and translate AI investments into meaningful business value. Please refer to the Manual for detailed Framework Application and Interpretation in the **Appendix**.

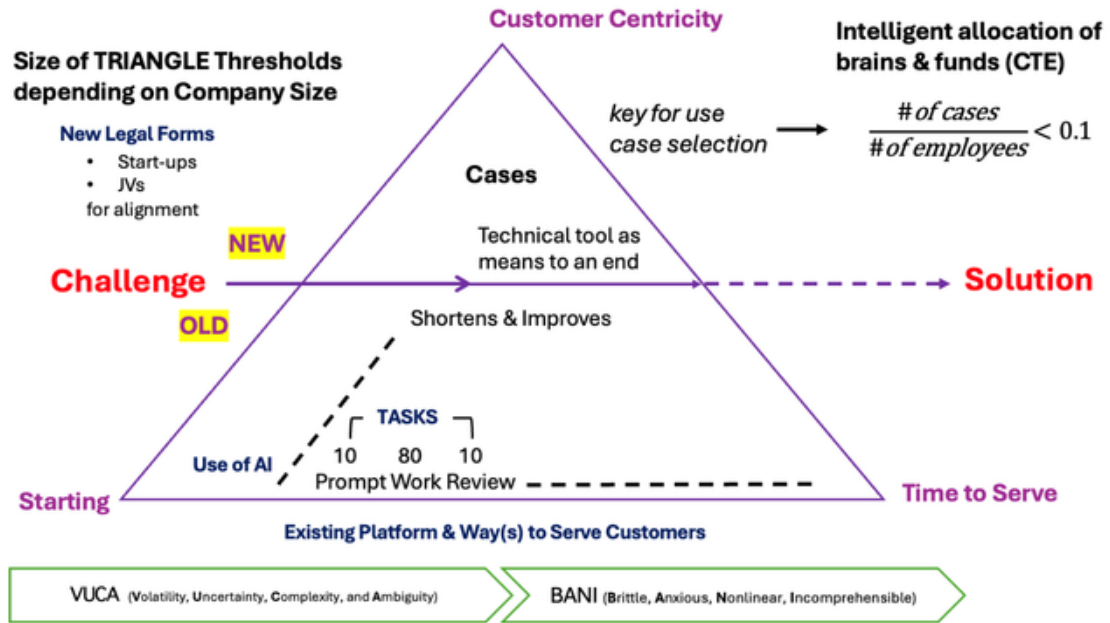


Figure 2. Frugal Framework for AI Implementation in Companies Operating under Conditions of Uncertainty

Banking

In banking, we are increasingly recognising that AI adoption is fundamentally a governance challenge as much as a technological one. As we integrate AI into credit decisions, risk assessment, and customer interactions, we must ensure that models are explainable, decisions are auditable, and accountability remains clearly defined. We see that strong corporate governance will require boards and leadership teams to develop a deeper understanding of AI systems, so that oversight is meaningful rather than symbolic. From our perspective, this also places responsibility on us to strengthen internal controls, align incentives with long-term outcomes, and avoid over-reliance on automated decision-making without human judgement. We are also more aware that regulatory expectations will evolve rapidly, and banks that proactively build transparent and responsible AI governance frameworks will be better positioned to maintain trust and resilience.

Non-Profit (CSR-Focused)

From a non-profit and CSR perspective, the programme reinforced for us that impact must now be both purpose-driven and systemically designed. We realised that many social initiatives remain

fragmented, while the challenges we face such as sustainability, inequality, and access require more integrated, scalable solutions. As board members and senior leaders, we see a growing responsibility to strengthen governance, ensure accountability, and align resources toward measurable long-term impact rather than short-term visibility. The discussions on AI and innovation also made us reflect on how technology can be responsibly leveraged to expand reach and improve effectiveness, while remaining inclusive and ethical. Going forward, we believe we must move beyond traditional CSR models and actively collaborate with industry, policymakers, and communities to build solutions that are both sustainable and transformative.

Healthcare

We are increasingly recognising that AI is not just an efficiency tool, but a critical enabler of better clinical and operational decision-making. The programme reinforced for us that the vast volume of healthcare data presents a unique opportunity to improve diagnosis, prediction, and patient outcomes, provided it is used responsibly and with strong governance. At the same time, we must ensure that the adoption of AI remains aligned with clinical judgment, patient safety, and ethical standards. Beyond technology, we were also struck by the strength of global collaboration, particularly between India and the UK, where talent, knowledge, and innovation ecosystems come together to create meaningful impact. Going forward, we believe healthcare leaders must focus on integrating technology with human expertise, while building systems that are both scalable and centred on patient trust and care quality.

FMCG

As founders in the FMCG space, we realised that scaling a brand is not only about product, operations, or resilience, but about how effectively we translate what we have built into the language of investors, partners, and global markets. The programme made us reflect that many first-generation entrepreneurs are not limited by capability, but by access to the frameworks and narratives that enable influence. In categories like tea, where products are deeply rooted in culture, storytelling, and experience, this challenge becomes even more pronounced in digital and global contexts. We now see that leadership requires not only building authentic brands, but also bridging lived experience with structured, strategic communication. This shift allows us to move from operating in isolation to engaging more effectively with ecosystems that enable growth, scale, and long-term impact.

Education

Our key leadership learning from the programme is that academia cannot evolve in isolation from practice. Engaging with global leaders across industries made it clear that while theory provides structure, real-world complexity often challenges and reshapes it. We realised that to remain relevant, we must actively step beyond traditional academic boundaries and engage directly with CEOs, CFOs, and industry leaders. This is particularly important in the context of AI and technological transformation, where the pace of change far exceeds conventional academic cycles. For us, this reinforces the need to integrate practice-driven insights into both research and teaching, ensuring that our work remains impactful and future-oriented. Leadership Programmes like this, offer a valuable platform for academics to immerse themselves in interdisciplinary, C-suite level thinking and better prepare the next generation of leaders.

Learning & Development (L&D)

In the L&D sector, we are increasingly recognising that executive education must move beyond content delivery toward curating environments that enable perspective shift and behavioural change. The programme reinforced for us that the most impactful learning happens not only through structured curriculum, but through peer exchange, challenge, and cross-industry dialogue, particularly at the C-suite level. This has direct implications for how we design leadership programmes across the Middle East and India, where clients are seeking not just knowledge, but transformation in thinking and decision-making. We see a growing need to integrate AI, global risk awareness, and interdisciplinary perspectives into programme design, while creating spaces that encourage unlearning as much as learning. Going forward, our focus will be on building learning ecosystems, not just programmes, that connect leaders across sectors and geographies to drive more relevant and sustained leadership impact.

Business Consulting and Services

We increasingly see that competitive advantage will come from the ability to integrate emerging technologies with disciplined capital allocation and governance. The programme reinforced for me that AI, sustainability, and geopolitical shifts are no longer separate considerations but interconnected forces shaping client strategy and long-term value. In our work, this translates into

helping organisations move beyond experimentation toward scalable, economically viable use cases, while ensuring responsible deployment. We were also reminded that effective consulting requires not just technical expertise, but the ability to guide clients through complex trade-offs under uncertainty, particularly in areas such as investment prioritisation and institutional stewardship. This experience sharpened my perspective that the role of consulting is evolving from problem-solving to enabling better judgment, where technology, strategy, and responsibility must be aligned.

Logistics and Supply Chain

We see that the next phase of transformation will be driven by how effectively we integrate AI into operational efficiency, visibility, and decision-making across the value chain. The programme made us reflect that while our industry has traditionally focused on execution, we now need to move toward data-driven operations, particularly in areas such as route optimisation, demand forecasting, and warehouse efficiency. We also recognise the importance of strengthening process transparency and governance, especially in customs clearance, compliance, and cross-border operations, where trust and accuracy are critical. Going forward, We aim to gradually embed AI-driven use cases into our operations to enhance reliability, speed, and customer experience.

A 6-Pillar Leadership Framework for the AI Era

1. Intelligent Systems & Decision-Making

AI is transforming leadership from execution to judgement. Leaders must move beyond using AI as a tool and instead integrate it into decision-making, while maintaining human oversight, critical thinking, and accountability.

2. Strategic Resilience in a Fragmented World

Globalisation is shifting towards regionalisation and geopolitical complexity. Leaders must build resilient organisations through diversified supply chains, local adaptability, and strong global partnerships.

3. Sustainability as a Core Strategy

Sustainability is no longer a compliance function but a driver of long-term value. Leaders must embed climate responsibility, ethical governance, and resource efficiency into core business strategy.

4. Governance, Trust & Accountability

As technology reshapes organisations, governance must evolve. Leaders must ensure transparency, ethical AI use, and strong institutional frameworks to maintain trust and long-term stability.

5. Human Capital & Leadership Culture

The future of leadership is human-centred. Organisations must invest in skills, inclusion, wellbeing, and culture to unlock the full potential of people in an AI-driven world.

6. Frugal & Context-Aware Innovation

Innovation must be practical, efficient, and inclusive. Leaders should adopt frugal, customer-centric approaches that work in real-world conditions, particularly in emerging and resource-constrained environments.

Part C: Future Priorities for Global Leaders: Perspectives from Emerging and Global Markets with the Rise of AI

This section compiles insights and reflections contributed by programme delegates (N = 22), each of whom demonstrated strong expertise in at least two interdisciplinary domains identified through a pre-programme survey. The survey assessed leadership competencies across six domains using a Likert scale from 1 to 7:

- Digital Transformation & Technology (mean 4.50)
- Strategic Growth & Internationalisation (mean 4.95)
- Sustainability & Ethics (mean 5.50)
- Leadership, Culture & Human Capital (mean 5.41)
- Corporate Governance & Institutional Frameworks (mean 4.22)
- Financial Stability & Economic Policy (mean 4.23)

These domains, conceptualised by the editor, provide a structured lens for understanding how global leaders perceive emerging challenges and opportunities. Drawing on the delegates' professional experiences across industries and markets, this section highlights key issues that leaders believe require greater attention over the next five years, particularly in the AI context of emerging and globally interconnected economies.

A. Digital Transformation & Technology

Santosh Huralikoppi, Anand Rao, Shipra Jha, Snigdha Sudhir Manchanda, Teck Ming Tan

The rise of artificial intelligence and emerging computational technologies marks a pivotal shift in the trajectory of digital transformation. Organisations are entering a period in which intelligence itself is becoming increasingly abundant. Advances in AI enable institutions to analyse complex systems, simulate strategic choices and accelerate innovation at unprecedented speed. Emerging technologies such as quantum computing further extend these capabilities, with the potential to solve problems that would take classical systems centuries to compute. For the first time, organisations are not merely using technology to enhance operational efficiency; they are beginning to work alongside increasingly capable systems of intelligence. Critically, **digitalisation remains constrained for SMEs by Western-centric platforms**, data asymmetry, and limited ability to capture cultural nuance, **creating structural barriers to authentic and sustainable growth**.

The central challenge for global leaders is not solely the power of these technologies, but the wisdom with which they are applied. Much of the past decade’s digital transformation agenda focused on operational efficiency, driven by cloud adoption, automation and data-driven optimisation. These investments established critical digital foundations. The next phase, however, will be significantly more transformative. Intelligent systems are beginning to shape how organisations learn, make decisions and adapt to uncertainty. Technology is therefore shifting from the operational periphery to the core of organisational thinking and strategic decision-making.

Within this transformation, organisations must recognise that digital transformation operates across two complementary dimensions. The first is **inward-facing**, encompassing internal functions such as finance, human resources and operational systems. The second is **outward-facing**, focusing on how organisations create value for users through products, services and customer experiences. Effective transformation requires leaders to continuously examine evolving user needs, changing expectations and the ways in which products, services and user experiences must evolve in response.

Crucially, digital transformation should not begin with technology selection but with a deep understanding of users and the value organisations seek to create for them. A human-centred perspective places people at the core of digital strategies. Organisations must intentionally design products, services and teams that reflect the diversity of the communities they serve, particularly those historically excluded from the “default user” definition. This includes women, queer communities, individuals from marginalised backgrounds and those at the intersections of multiple forms of exclusion. Designing digital systems for and with these communities strengthens both inclusivity and innovation.

Emerging markets provide particularly valuable perspectives in this context. Organisations operating within these environments routinely navigate complex social, economic and cultural intersections. As a result, they bring both representation that has historically been absent from global technology discourse and practical expertise in designing solutions for diverse and dynamic contexts. Their insights can play a critical role in shaping more inclusive and adaptive models of digital transformation.

Key takeaways for global leaders include several priorities. First, digital transformation should move beyond efficiency-driven adoption toward the strategic integration of intelligent systems into organisational learning and decision-making. Second, leaders must balance technological capability with governance, ensuring that AI and emerging technologies are guided by human judgement to prevent the amplification of bias and systemic risk. Third, successful

transformation requires a human-centred approach that begins with understanding evolving user needs rather than prioritising technological tools. Fourth, organisations should intentionally incorporate diverse perspectives, particularly those from historically underrepresented communities and emerging markets to design more inclusive and effective digital solutions. Finally, long-term success will depend on building the institutional capacity, infrastructure and skills required to responsibly harness the growing abundance of machine intelligence.

B. Strategic Growth & Internationalisation

Sanj Naha, Vinit Pardeshi, Aashish Chaudhry, Rama Shankar Pandey, Parag Bawdekar, Anand Rao, Sneha Bhat, Mahabeer Prasad, Caroline Reiners

Strategic growth and internationalisation are entering a period of profound transformation shaped by technological disruption, geopolitical uncertainty and shifting economic structures. While global expansion was historically driven by market size, cost advantages and speed of entry, the emerging environment requires a broader and more systemic approach. Leaders must increasingly navigate a world influenced by geopolitical tensions, supply chain vulnerabilities and rapid technological change. Growth strategies that focus only on short term market opportunities risk becoming fragile in such conditions.

One important dimension influencing the global economic landscape is the concentration of influence among major technology leaders and firms. The strategic decisions and technological investments of a small number of powerful technology actors increasingly shape innovation ecosystems, digital infrastructure and global market dynamics. At the same time, emerging technologies such as the convergence of artificial intelligence and quantum computing have the potential to redefine competitive advantage, accelerate scientific discovery and reshape industrial capabilities.

Globalisation itself is evolving. Instead of a single integrated global system, economic activity is increasingly organised into regional blocs influenced by geopolitical competition, trade restrictions and supply chain security concerns. In this context, organisations must rethink the structure of their global operations. Multi regional supply chains, diversified sourcing strategies and stronger resilience planning are becoming essential. Businesses can no longer rely on a single global network designed purely for cost efficiency. Instead, they must build flexibility and redundancy into their international strategies.

Infrastructure capacity remains a critical determinant of digital and economic growth. In many countries, the pace of digital transformation is constrained by physical infrastructure such as power grids, fibre networks and data centres. At the same time, digital sovereignty and data governance are emerging as central policy considerations, influencing how data flows, technology development and cross border operations will evolve.

Demographic divergence will also shape global economic trajectories. While some economies are experiencing rapidly ageing populations, others have expanding youth demographics. These shifts will influence labour markets, consumption patterns and long-term economic competitiveness. Talent mobility and migration will therefore play an increasingly important role in determining national and organisational growth potential. Rapid urbanisation, climate adaptation, water security and sustainable agriculture are also becoming central economic challenges that leaders must address alongside traditional growth objectives.

At the organisational level, leaders increasingly recognise the need to adopt new ways of doing business and integrate emerging technologies into their operations. The adoption of artificial intelligence can help reduce costs by automating repetitive work and improving operational efficiency. However, sustainable growth depends not only on technological adoption but also on strengthening organisational capabilities, leadership capacity and strategic resilience.

International expansion also requires deeper institutional awareness. Strong governance structures, regulatory systems and legal frameworks are essential foundations for sustainable economic activity, particularly in emerging markets. Leaders must therefore develop systemic thinking capabilities that allow them to view markets not only as commercial opportunities but as interconnected systems involving governments, communities, infrastructure and talent ecosystems. Building long term relationships and aligning organisational ambitions with societal priorities becomes increasingly important in such environments.

Another important capability is balancing global scale with local intelligence. Companies that simply replicate business models across borders often struggle to gain relevance in diverse contexts. Organisations that empower local teams, listen to market signals and adapt products and services to local needs are better positioned to achieve durable growth. Markets such as India, Vietnam and other parts of Southeast Asia are increasingly sources of innovation, resilience and new business models that can inform strategies globally.

Finally, internationalisation increasingly involves collaboration as well as expansion. Strong global networks, alliances and partnerships are becoming essential for addressing complex cross border challenges and unlocking new opportunities. Participation in international learning platforms and

leadership networks also strengthens the ability of leaders to exchange perspectives, foster innovation and develop globally relevant leadership capabilities.

Key takeaways for global leaders include several priorities. First, growth strategies must shift from speed and scale alone toward resilience, systemic awareness and long-term integration with local economies and institutions. Second, organisations should prepare for a more fragmented global system by building multi regional supply chains and diversified sourcing strategies. Third, leaders must invest in infrastructure readiness, digital governance and talent mobility to support sustainable international expansion. Fourth, technological transformation, including the integration of AI and emerging computational capabilities, should be accompanied by investments in organisational capabilities and leadership development. Finally, successful internationalisation will depend on balancing global ambition with local intelligence while building strong partnerships and collaborative networks across regions.

C. Sustainability & Ethics

Bidisha Banerjee, Johannes Mario Schmidt, Chandrashekhar Meled, Rajesh Pandey, Rama Shankar Pandey, Johannes Samwer, Fatin Al Zadjali, Sneha Bhat, Teck Ming Tan

Sustainability and ethics are becoming central pillars of global leadership and long-term economic stability, particularly in emerging markets. Over the next decade, organisations will face increasing pressure to move beyond symbolic commitments and integrate sustainability into the core of their strategic and operational decision making. While many companies have adopted environmental, social and governance reporting frameworks, several critical issues remain insufficiently addressed. These include climate adaptation, ethical governance of artificial intelligence, water scarcity, supply chain transparency and biodiversity protection. Addressing these challenges will require organisations to move from reporting-based approaches toward measurable and credible action.

From a financial leadership perspective, sustainability is increasingly evolving from a compliance obligation into a strategic financial discipline. Long term value creation will depend on embedding climate resilience, responsible capital allocation and strong governance practices into core business strategies. Financial leaders must integrate climate and resource risks into financial planning processes, ensure transparent governance to attract global capital and direct investment toward sustainable infrastructure, energy transition and resilient supply chains. In this context, the role of financial leadership is expanding beyond traditional stewardship toward a broader strategic responsibility for sustainability and long-term value creation.

At the same time, sustainability represents both a major global challenge and a strategic opportunity for organisations. Adjusting products, services and operational practices to align with sustainability principles is increasingly becoming a guiding framework for long term competitiveness. Companies that fail to recognise the significance of this transition risk undermining their long-term legitimacy and losing their licence to operate. Although regulatory expectations and customer adoption may evolve gradually, organisations that delay adaptation may find it difficult to respond once market and regulatory shifts accelerate.

Ethical considerations are equally critical in guiding organisational behaviour in this evolving landscape. **Ethical frameworks provide orientation and reliability that extend beyond formal legal requirements and corporate policies.** In particular, concerns about greenwashing are becoming more prominent as organisations publicly commit to sustainability initiatives without fully implementing meaningful change. Ensuring that sustainability efforts are credible, measurable and transparent is therefore essential for maintaining public trust and investor confidence.

The urgency of action is reinforced by increasing evidence of global warming and environmental stress. Stakeholders across governments, academia and civil society are raising concerns about the long-term viability of the planet and the need to create conditions for future generations. International agreements such as the Paris Accord and the Sustainable Development Goals provide important frameworks for coordinated global action. For many emerging market organisations, measuring carbon footprints and implementing sustainability strategies remains a developing capability. Smaller and medium sized enterprises in particular often face challenges in measurement and regulatory oversight, yet their participation is essential for achieving meaningful progress.

Sustainability efforts must also incorporate inclusive economic development. Strengthening local capabilities, supporting responsible supply ecosystems and promoting inclusive growth are important components of sustainable development strategies, particularly in emerging markets where economic development and environmental responsibility must advance simultaneously. Further, sustainability must also be viewed through a social lens—advancing equity, inclusion, and fair opportunity as integral elements of responsible leadership.

Key takeaways for global leaders include several priorities. First, sustainability must shift from a reporting exercise toward a strategic framework embedded in financial planning, operational decision making and long-term organisational strategy. Second, leaders must address overlooked sustainability challenges including climate adaptation, water scarcity, ethical governance of artificial intelligence and biodiversity protection. Third, organisations must ensure

transparency and credibility in sustainability initiatives to prevent greenwashing and strengthen public trust. Fourth, investment strategies should prioritise sustainable infrastructure, energy transition and resilient supply chains while supporting inclusive economic development. Finally, meaningful progress will require stronger regulatory frameworks, improved measurement capabilities and broader participation across both large enterprises and small and medium sized businesses.

D. Leadership, Culture & Human Capital

Bidisha Banerjee, Sanj Naha, Johannes Mario Schmidt, Chandrashekhar Meled, Vinit Pardeshi, Aashish Chaudhry, Rajesh Pandey, Amarjit Singh, Johannes Samwer, Snigdha Sudhir Manchanda

Currently, leadership and human capital challenges in emerging markets include **structural disadvantages for first-generation founders**, limited access to sponsorship networks, and the **under-recognition of wellbeing as a systemic issue**, constraining talent development, leadership sustainability, and long-term economic potential. The coming decade will place unprecedented demands on leadership as organisations navigate rapid technological transformation, demographic change, climate pressures and global economic volatility. In such an environment, leadership effectiveness will increasingly depend on the ability to cultivate resilient organisational cultures and develop human capital as a strategic priority. As artificial intelligence, robotics and automation reshape industries, human skills such as problem solving, adaptability and critical thinking will become increasingly valuable. Education and professional training systems will need to evolve to prepare individuals for a world in which intelligent machines possess expanding knowledge capabilities. At the same time, organisations will need to address rising expectations around purpose, inclusion, and **psychological safety, particularly among younger, globally mobile talent**.

The acceleration of automation also raises important social and organisational challenges. As more tasks become automated, many individuals may experience uncertainty regarding job security and professional identity. Organisations must therefore support employees in navigating transitions by investing in reskilling, continuous learning and new forms of career development. In this context, human capital is no longer simply a supporting resource but one of the most critical assets for long term organisational competitiveness.

Leadership must also shift its focus beyond operational efficiency toward the creation of strong organisational cultures that empower people and encourage innovation. This includes fostering ethical decision making, collaborative leadership models and adaptive mindsets capable of responding to constant change. Leadership must integrate technological progress responsibly while ensuring that organisational cultures remain grounded in human values and long-term societal considerations.

Several structural forces are intensifying the need for new leadership capabilities. Technological transformation, demographic shifts and global uncertainty are redefining how organisations operate and compete. Leaders must therefore cultivate cultures that emphasise continuous learning, talent mobility, diversity and inclusion and employee well-being. These factors increasingly determine whether organisations can attract, retain and develop the talent required to thrive in rapidly evolving markets.

A growing trust deficit in institutions and organisations further highlights the importance of ethical leadership. Transparency, accountability and consistent ethical behaviour are becoming essential foundations for organisational legitimacy. At the same time, leadership in global and emerging markets requires strong cultural intelligence. Effective leaders cannot rely on exporting a single leadership model across different contexts. Instead, they must understand diverse cultural dynamics and adapt leadership approaches accordingly.

Within organisations, middle management is becoming a critical but often overlooked layer responsible for translating strategic vision into operational execution. As organisations undergo continuous transformation, middle managers face increasing pressure to implement change while supporting employees through periods of uncertainty. Strengthening leadership capabilities at this level is therefore essential for maintaining organisational cohesion and effectiveness.

At the same time, organisations are facing a widening human capital gap between highly skilled digital talent and workers who lack access to advanced skills in areas such as artificial intelligence and data science. Demographic changes are also creating multistage career environments in which individuals work longer and require continuous opportunities for reskilling and leadership development. Successfully managing these dynamics requires leaders to coordinate diverse talent pools and invest systematically in workforce development.

Effective leadership is also closely linked to organisational culture. Leadership plays a defining role in shaping and demonstrating the values that guide organisational behaviour. As widely recognised in management thought, culture can strongly influence the success of strategic initiatives. Human

resources therefore represent a critical differentiator in enabling organisations to achieve their goals.

This relationship can be expressed conceptually through the following leadership framework (**Leadership × Culture × Human Capital**). In this formulation, leadership provides direction and vision, culture establishes the behavioural norms that guide collective action and human capital represents the capabilities that enable organisations to execute their strategies. The interaction of these three elements determines organisational performance in much the same way that financial performance may depend on factors such as margin, productivity and working capital.

Key takeaways for global leaders include several priorities. First, organisations must treat human capital as a strategic asset by investing in continuous learning, reskilling and inclusive talent development. Second, leaders should cultivate organisational cultures grounded in ethical decision making, transparency and collaboration in order to rebuild trust in institutions and strengthen organisational legitimacy. Third, leadership approaches must adapt to diverse cultural and demographic contexts rather than relying on uniform global models. Fourth, organisations should strengthen middle management capabilities so that strategic priorities can be effectively translated during periods of rapid technological and organisational transformation. Fifth, global leaders should actively engage with international leadership networks and participate in **executive short-term education programmes (e.g., Global Education Lab) affiliated with leading institutions, such as the University of Cambridge**, to exchange perspectives, strengthen global collaboration and continuously update leadership capabilities in an evolving global environment. Finally, long term leadership effectiveness will depend on the alignment of leadership vision, organisational culture and human capital development in order to navigate an increasingly complex and technology driven world.

E. Corporate Governance & Institutional Frameworks

Sam Tully, Santosh Huralikoppi, Vikramjeet Singh, Amarjit Singh, Shipra Jha

In an era characterised by technological disruption, geopolitical turbulence and economic uncertainty, strong corporate governance and effective institutional frameworks are becoming increasingly critical for organisational resilience and long-term value creation. Governance operates at two interconnected levels. The first relates to the internal culture and practices of an organisation, including how decisions are made, how accountability is maintained and how

leadership structure's function. The second concerns the broader legal, regulatory and institutional frameworks that shape corporate behaviour within national and global economic systems.

Within organisations, governance quality is strongly influenced by internal structures such as board composition, the quality of governance debates and the clarity of decision-making processes. Boards play a central role in safeguarding the interests of shareholders while ensuring that organisational strategies align with ethical and legal standards. Transparent governance processes, balanced representation and effective oversight mechanisms are therefore essential for maintaining organisational credibility and strategic stability.

External factors also provide important signals regarding the strength of governance practices. A company's record of regulatory, legal and environmental compliance offers valuable insight into its governance standards. Equally significant is how organisations engage with governments, investors and regulatory authorities. In many cases, weaknesses in governance practices are eventually reflected in corporate valuation, as investors increasingly assess companies not only on financial performance but also on governance integrity and institutional reliability.

These governance challenges are particularly pronounced in environments where institutional frameworks are still developing. In emerging economies, regulatory structures, enforcement mechanisms and governance norms may still be evolving. At the same time, even developed economies are experiencing political and institutional pressures that can complicate governance systems. The key challenge for the coming decade will therefore be to strengthen both the internal pillars of corporate governance and the broader institutional frameworks that support transparency, accountability and responsible corporate conduct.

In specialised sectors such as healthcare, governance frameworks must also incorporate rigorous ethical and professional standards. Accreditation processes, such as hospital quality certifications and international healthcare standards, help ensure that care delivery follows evidence based medical guidelines and established best practices. Institutional mechanisms such as ethics committees and review boards play an important role in overseeing research ethics, clinical risk management and quality assurance. As digital health technologies expand, governance frameworks must also address the responsible integration of artificial intelligence tools into clinical decision making, including the validation of AI systems and their safe integration into clinical workflows.

The rapid integration of advanced technologies across industries also introduces new governance responsibilities. Leadership teams increasingly require technological literacy to effectively oversee digital systems and ensure that human oversight remains meaningful. The concept of maintaining a human presence in decision loops raises important questions about whether individuals

responsible for oversight are equipped with the tools and knowledge needed to perform this role effectively.

Institutional governance must therefore evaluate technological systems not only for their technical capabilities but also for their ethical and social implications. Issues such as algorithmic bias, lack of transparency, unintended societal consequences and accountability for automated decisions require careful consideration. Addressing these challenges often requires a broader and more interdisciplinary perspective. Incorporating the insights of technologists, social scientists, ethicists and representatives from diverse communities can help reduce blind spots and improve the quality of governance decisions.

In this context, organisations are increasingly being evaluated not only on their ability to adopt advanced technologies but also on how responsibly and inclusively they deploy them. Emerging markets can offer valuable insights in this regard. Countries such as India often operate within complex social environments and resource constrained systems, providing practical experience in managing diverse stakeholder expectations while maintaining institutional adaptability.

Key takeaways for global leaders include several priorities. First, organisations must strengthen internal governance structures through effective board composition, transparent decision making and strong accountability mechanisms. Second, leaders must reinforce compliance with regulatory, legal and environmental standards while maintaining constructive engagement with investors and public institutions. Third, **AI governance frameworks** must evolve to oversee emerging technologies responsibly, including ensuring meaningful human oversight and addressing ethical risks such as bias and lack of transparency. Fourth, interdisciplinary perspectives should be integrated into governance discussions to improve decision quality and reduce institutional blind spots. Finally, strengthening institutional frameworks in both emerging and developed economies will be essential for sustaining trust, responsible innovation and long-term economic stability.

F. Financial Stability & Economic Policy

Sam Tully, Vikramjeet Singh, Fatin Al Zadjali, Mahabeer Prasad, Caroline Reiners

Financial stability and economic policy are becoming increasingly complex in a world shaped by rapid technological change and geopolitical uncertainty. For global leaders, these two forces will likely define the economic environment over the next five years. Technological change continues to transform industries, financial systems and investment priorities. Emerging fields such as

advanced scientific computing, including quantum computing and bio computing, are expected to influence future innovation and investment patterns. These technologies may reshape productivity, research capabilities and industrial competitiveness, creating both opportunities and strategic uncertainties for organisations and governments.

At the same time, geopolitical developments are contributing to a more unstable and fragmented global economic landscape. Trade tensions, regional conflicts and shifting political alliances are generating economic disruptions that affect supply chains, inflation dynamics and access to critical resources. These developments can result in market volatility, price fluctuations, currency instability and challenges in accessing finance. As global economies become increasingly interconnected, disruptions in one region can rapidly reverberate across financial markets and economic systems worldwide.

In such conditions, global leaders must develop the capability to manage and adapt to ongoing disruption. Strategic responses may include diversifying markets and supply chains, strengthen sustainability practices and adopt more targeted and forward-looking investment strategies. Rather than attempting to eliminate volatility entirely, organisations increasingly need to learn how to operate effectively within unstable environments and identify opportunities that arise from structural shifts in the global economy.

Financial resilience within organisations also depends on sound resource management and operational efficiency. Effective budget planning, cost control and resource allocation remain essential management functions, particularly in sectors such as healthcare where leaders must balance financial sustainability with service quality and accessibility. Improving efficiency, reducing operational waste and implementing sound risk management and legal compliance practices contribute to stronger financial stability. At the same time, innovation can create new revenue opportunities through initiatives such as specialised services, digital platforms and telemedicine solutions.

Economic policy also plays a critical role in stabilising financial ecosystems. Governments and regulatory authorities must intervene through timely reforms that support financial system stability, maintain liquidity and protect consumers. Ensuring access to finance, maintaining reliable financial infrastructure and supporting stable markets are essential for sustaining economic activity. When geopolitical turbulence disrupts established systems, coordinated policy responses become necessary to reduce systemic risks and restore market confidence.

Financial stability is also closely connected to real economic sectors such as agriculture and manufacturing. Rising input costs and unstable market prices can create significant challenges for

producers, particularly small-scale farmers and entrepreneurs. Innovation, cost reduction strategies and value addition within production systems can help improve economic resilience in such sectors. Strengthening market access and supporting more efficient production methods can contribute to the long-term financial stability and dignity of farming communities while supporting broader economic growth.

At the firm level, increasing global interconnectedness has made organisations more vulnerable to sudden external shocks. Sudden shifts in energy prices, supply chain disruptions, changes in interest rates or geopolitical tensions can quickly destabilise even well performing firms. Environments that were once relatively stable can change rapidly within short periods of time. As a result, organisations must prioritise contingency planning, maintain strong financial reserves and develop robust safety strategies to withstand periods of economic turbulence.

Key takeaways for global leaders include several priorities. First, leaders must closely monitor the economic implications of technological change, including emerging computing technologies that may reshape investment and productivity dynamics. Second, organisations must build resilience against geopolitical disruption through diversified markets, supply chains and investment strategies. Third, strong financial management practices, including efficient resource allocation, risk management and innovation driven revenue generation, remain essential for organisational stability. Fourth, policymakers must support stable financial ecosystems through effective regulatory frameworks and timely economic interventions. Finally, long term financial resilience will depend on diversification, strong organisational capabilities and disciplined financial planning in an increasingly volatile global economy.

Appendix

Manual

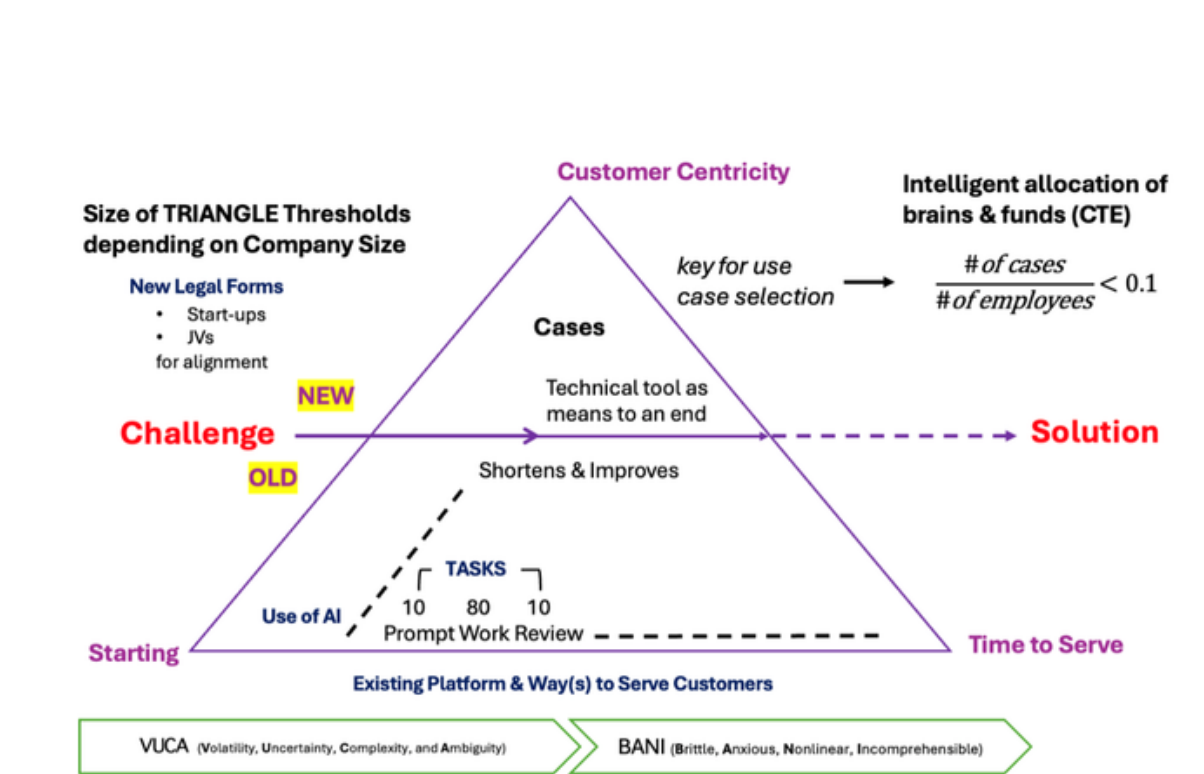
Frugal Framework for AI Implementation in Companies Operating under Conditions of Uncertainty

Original concept by: Johannes Samwer

Edited by: Teck Ming Tan

Place: Newton Room, The Pitt Building, University of Cambridge, UK

Event: Global India Leadership Programme, Global Education Lab



1. Purpose of the framework

To guide leaders in prioritising and allocating AI initiatives for efficiency and innovation under uncertainty, with a strong focus on customer value.

2. Key Leadership Principle in AI Implementation

Prioritise customer-centric AI use cases, balancing efficiency and innovation, while allocating resources deliberately and limiting initiatives in line with organizational capacity and strategy.

3. Framework Explanation and Application

This framework supports leaders in prioritising AI use cases under conditions of uncertainty, while maintaining a strong focus on **customer centricity** as the overarching principle.

The **X-axis** represents the time required to fulfil customers' traditional needs and requirements. As organisations identify and implement more AI-driven automation use cases, they become more efficient—moving along the triangle by **shortening time to serve**, reducing errors, and improving execution. This applies at all levels, from individual contributors to teams, departments, and the entire organisation.

The **Y-axis** represents the ability to **redefine offerings for existing customers or create value for new customers**. The framework highlights a **natural barrier**, where AI improves existing processes but does not yet deliver fundamentally new solutions. Beyond this point, organizations must pursue new use cases that enable new customer experiences or services, entering new strategic territory. The number of such initiatives should be aligned with the company's size and strategy.

A central leadership responsibility is to prioritise the most promising AI initiatives. As a rule of thumb, organisations should pursue **no more than one AI project per ten full-time employees (FTEs)**. This is reinforced by the **case-to-employee (CTE) ratio**, where the number of use cases divided by the number of employees should remain **below 0.1**. Leaders must also **consciously allocate both financial resources and talent ("brains")** to each initiative, and determine the appropriate structure, such as internal projects, start-ups, or joint ventures, particularly for more advanced use cases.

Operationally, AI deployment follows a **10–80–10 task structure**, where approximately 10% of effort is dedicated to prompt design, 80% to AI-driven execution, and 10% to human review, ensuring efficiency while maintaining quality and oversight.

The framework also reflects the broader context of increasing uncertainty, transitioning from **VUCA** (Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, Ambiguity) to **BANI** (Brittle, Anxious, Nonlinear, Incomprehensible) environments. This reinforces the need for a disciplined, selective, and frugal approach to AI implementation.

Importantly, AI is positioned as a technical tool serving a broader purpose, not an end in itself. The guiding question for all initiatives should remain: **what customer problem is being addressed, and how does AI enable a better solution?**

Overall, the framework guides leaders in moving from unstructured experimentation (“old”) to deliberate, prioritised, and scalable AI implementation (“new”), balancing efficiency improvements with strategic innovation.

Global Education Lab

Cambridge, United Kingdom

www.globaledulab.com

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